

Laving says. That ‘feeds into the denial process that comes with this behaviour’.

Laving has based her teachings for her online clinic, Steps to Simplicity, on the work of American psychologist Dr April Benson, who is a global guru when it comes to retail-based disorders and destructive spending. Laving contacted Dr Benson for a research paper, struck up a relationship and established her own program using Benson’s strategies, which she delivers to clients via Skype, Australia-wide.

Cutting back on spending requires a similar approach to quitting smoking. Laving has launched an interactive text messaging program, the first in Australia, which, like nicotine abstinence apps, sends affirmations and reminders to keep clients focused. Here’s how it works: sign up to the text message program for three months, after filling out a questionnaire based on your shopping profile and financial goals. The app sends two or three texts a day as a mix of information, motivational messages and specific calendar-type prompts to avoid dates or times when you are most vulnerable to spending. You can text the system if the urge to shop arises – or if you are shopping – and it replies with a supportive text within 30 seconds, and another text eight minutes later.

Steps to Simplicity

Michelle Laving’s Steps to Simplicity have been created for problem compulsive shoppers, but you might find some of them effective for your own circumstances, given you need to be militantly frugal, in the long term, in order to buy a home.

1. Basic computer and smartphone hacks

Consider downloading ad-blocking apps and adjusting your browser settings to prevent pop-up ads of items you have previously looked at. Cookies are a roadmap of your web surfing habits; they’re the reason you feel ‘stalked’ by brands online – they know when you visited and whether you are a repeat customer. It’s a clever and insidious marketing play, but you can put up a protective wall against it.